

Branching and boundary tests

Project: Python readiness portfolio

1. Prepare the purpose, prerequisites and materials

Teach the learning cycle

Primary target: Trace the selected branch in an if elif else chain

Session · Sequence and minutes · Resources

Session: Session 1 · Understand · 45 min

Sequence and minutes: 0–7: recall and prerequisite; 7–15: inspect the concrete case and predict; 15–30: teacher models the worked trace; 30–40: learners explain a step using the text and visual; 40–45: check the core idea.

Resources: Sections 1–6; record the brief recall in the workbook.

Session: Session 2 · Practise · 45 min

Sequence and minutes: 0–5: retrieve the procedure; 5–15: W2 completion practice; 15–23: explain and check with a partner; 23–30: each learner answers the misconception check; 30–40: targeted reteaching or a harder variation; 40–45: prepare the investigation.

Resources: Sections 7–10; use the matching workbook W2 and misconception check.

Session: Session 3 · Investigate and transfer · 45 min

Sequence and minutes: 0–5: retrieve the decision rule; 5–20: investigate or trace; 20–30: start the independent case; 30–38: connect the project; 38–43: act on feedback; 43–45: plan the return check.

Resources: Sections 9 and 11–14. Give extra time to finish the full task set; use Section 15 when the week includes a coding lab.

This is a starting allocation of 135 minutes, not a validated duration. Preserve all named topics. Schedule extra time for connected examples, the full investigation, independent cases and project building. Repeated copies of a case share one recorded attempt; they are not new evidence.

Case exposure check: this source example appears in ai-2/3, python-bridge/5. Reuse a familiar case for

recall or modelling; verify that the case used to assess transfer has not already received feedback.

Retrieval answer guidance

Boolean conditions

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Boolean conditions. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Look for: Translate stated requirements into comparisons

Reference example, not the only acceptable wording: (minutes $\leq$ 12) and quiet. At most includes equality, so $\leq$ is required; the nonnegative integer and Boolean input contract still applies.

Values variables and types

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Values variables and types. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Look for: Distinguish integer, floating-point, text and Boolean values

Reference example, not the only acceptable wording: 12 is int; 1.5 is float; "12" is str; False is bool; "False" is str. Quotes mark text even when the characters spell a Boolean name.

Teach ordered selection and indentation using a written input contract. A script can cover all branches while missing an equality bug. Reference: <https://docs.python.org/3/tutorial/controlflow.html#if-statements>. The new task requires one four-way chain; independently correct equivalent conditions are acceptable.

Outcomes

Trace the selected branch in an if elif else chain

Use indentation to identify which statements belong to a branch

Test values at and around a decision boundary

Preparation

Python 3 editor and branches.py

The written duration rule and boundary case cards

Blank trace table with a skipped marker

Prerequisite answer

$\leq$ accepts equality; $<$ excludes it. At 12 the two conditions produce different Boolean values.

End goal for the pictorial case

Trace branching and boundary tests and explain the changed program before running it.

This added worked case illustrates the week's main idea. Retain all original and connected topics; schedule its practice within the teaching cycle.

2. Explain and model the mechanism

A fictional activity sorter labels a supplied integer duration. Negative values are Invalid; values from zero through 12 are Short; larger values are Long. The labels describe duration only. Write this requirement before the program so that a test has an expected answer independent of the code.

An if statement selects a block when its condition is true. An elif is considered only if earlier conditions in the same chain were false. An else handles the remaining cases. Colons end the condition lines. Use four spaces for the indented statements and keep related branches aligned.

The output is Short. For 12, the first condition is false and the second is true. The else block is skipped. `print(label)` is not indented, so it runs after the selected branch. Each path assigns label before this line reads it. Change only minutes and save before each fresh run.

Term · Meaning

Term: Branch

Meaning: A possible path through a program

Term: Condition

Meaning: An expression used to decide which path to take

Term: Indentation

Meaning: Leading spaces that identify a Python code block

Term: Boundary

Meaning: A value where a classification may change

Term: Regression check

Meaning: A previous test rerun after an edit to detect a new failure

One chain chooses one label

Input · Checks in order · Selected label

Input: -1

Checks in order: Below zero is True

Selected label: Invalid

Input: 12

Checks in order: Below zero False; ≤ 12 True

Selected label: Short

Input: 13

Checks in order: Both checks False

Selected label: Long

Later branches in this chain are skipped after a condition succeeds.

The faulty < 12 version prints Long for 12, contrary to the inclusive Short rule. Repair to ≤ 12 and rerun 11 or 13 as well as 12. Exit: exact 12 is missing. -1, 2 and 20 can visit all branches even when the equality comparison is wrong.

Model the reasoning aloud

Use the complete worked example below before asking learners to complete W2. Reveal a small part, invite a prediction, then explain the deciding step. These teacher notes contain solutions; do not reveal the independent case answer during modelling.

-1 · Invalid · Negative input rejection

-1: 0

Invalid: Short

Negative input rejection: Lowest valid duration

-1: 11

Invalid: Short

Negative input rejection: Just below the upper boundary

-1: 12

Invalid: Short

Negative input rejection: Exact upper boundary

-1: 13

Invalid: Long

Negative input rejection: Just above the boundary

These tests exercise every branch and the equality case. A change from ≤ 12 to < 12 is exposed by 12; testing 11 alone misses it. Branch coverage means every branch was exercised, but it does not prove every condition is correct.

Suppose the program uses < 12 instead of ≤ 12 . What is printed for 12, why does that violate the written rule, and which earlier test should still pass after repair?

Thinking move · Teacher prompt

Thinking move: Plan

Teacher prompt: What is given? What is the question? Which procedure fits these facts?

Thinking move: Do

Teacher prompt: Point to each input and intermediate step in the worked trace. Name the rule that allows the next step.

Thinking move: Check

Teacher prompt: Does the output answer the question? Which assumption or limitation prevents a larger claim?

Use the diagram and verbal explanation together. Ask learners to match a sentence to a specific visual

step; do not assign learners fixed visual or auditory learning styles.

A pictorial worked case: Branching and boundary tests

Check invalid values before branching. A toy shelf label uses fewer than five books as "small", otherwise "large", but negative counts are invalid.

The facts we will use

Python 3: `if count<0: label="invalid"; elif count<5: label="small"; else: label="large"`. Read as indented branches.

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Branching and boundary tests

Start with the supplied facts

Follow each arrow. Ask which fact allows the next step.



1. Check validity

For count=-2, the first condition selects invalid.



2. Check small boundary

For count=4, validity passes and count<5 selects small.



3. Handle equality

For count=5, both earlier conditions fail, so large is selected.

CHANGE ONE THING

Remove the first negative-count branch.

Explain the changed result using the matching lesson.

Read the picture one step at a time

Step · What happens and why

Step: 1. Check validity

What happens and why: For count=-2, the first condition selects invalid.

Step: 2. Check small boundary

What happens and why: For count=4, validity passes and count<5 selects small.

Step: 3. Handle equality

What happens and why: For count=5, both earlier conditions fail, so large is selected.

Match each pictured step to the supplied facts. This is a worked teaching case, not an independent assessment.

Why this result follows

An if/elif/else chain selects the first matching branch. Putting invalid handling first prevents a negative count from being mislabelled as a small valid collection.

What this example does not establish

The toy procedure assumes numeric counts; validate types and define missing-value behaviour before using it in a real service.

Change one thing in the pictured case

Change: Remove the first negative-count branch.

Prediction: A count of -2 would incorrectly receive small.

Reason: Negative two is less than five, but it is not a permitted measured count.

Ask while showing the picture

Cover the result. Ask learners to name the inputs and predict the next step. Uncover one step, connect the icon to the actual procedure, and explain its evidence. Then change the supplied condition and compare. The picture is a representation; it does not document execution of a real AI model.

3. Demonstrate and guide practice

Time or stage · Teacher action

Time or stage: Session 1 start to 7 minutes

Teacher action: Retrieve inclusive comparison and collect the prerequisite.

Time or stage: 7 to 20 minutes

Teacher action: Translate the duration rule and complete W1.

Time or stage: 20 to 33 minutes

Teacher action: Trace the diagram and code, marking skipped branches.

Time or stage: 33 to 45 minutes

Teacher action: Complete W2 with predicted and actual outputs.

Time or stage: Session 2 start to 8 minutes

Teacher action: Retrieve why equality needs a separate test.

Time or stage: 8 to 20 minutes

Teacher action: Run the faulty two-if script and complete W3 and the guided question.

Time or stage: 20 to 35 minutes

Teacher action: Collect the new sorter in W4 before hints.

Time or stage: 35 to 45 minutes

Teacher action: Use W5 and the exit to distinguish coverage from correctness.

Use the worked example in Sections 3 and 6. Collect a prediction before revealing its result; ask the learner to point to each intermediate fact.

Provide movable branch cards and align the four-space blocks on a ruled page. Permit an oral trace alongside the script and record help. Extension: swap the zero and ≤ 6 checks and find the smallest nonnegative counterexample.

Reduce help deliberately

Completion task: For -1, 12 and 13, record checked conditions, skipped conditions and the final label. Run each as a fresh script after predicting.

Teacher check: -1: first True, second skipped, Invalid. 12: first False, second True, Short. 13: both False,

else selected, Long. Retain observed results separately.

Start by identifying the given inputs together. Leave the intermediate steps blank. If needed, model one step, then withdraw that help on the next step. Move to a full trace only when the partial trace is understood. For partners, alternate explainer and checker; collect a response from every learner before discussion.

Individual reasoning check

Use the worked case for Branching and boundary tests. Proposed explanation: “Every condition in the chain always runs”. Decide whether this explanation is supported. Point to the step or supplied fact that decides; explain your repair if needed.

Expected correction: Once one condition succeeds, later alternatives are skipped.

Collect explanations, not only yes/no votes. If a misunderstanding is common, re-model the relevant step for the class. If it affects a few learners, give a short targeted group explanation while others solve a more demanding variation.

Pictorial practice question

Trace -2, 4 and 5 through the branches. Explain why the negative check comes first and what label -2 gets if it is removed.

Reasoned teacher answer

The labels are invalid, small and large. The first branch stops negative inputs before the small rule. Without it, $-2 < 5$ produces small and breaks the input contract.

Changed-case reasoning: A count of -2 would incorrectly receive small. Negative two is less than five, but it is not a permitted measured count.

Collect each learner’s explanation before discussion. Use the first missing connection between input, deciding step and result to choose support. This question is worked-case practice, not fresh mastery evidence.

4. Run the investigation and diagnose misconceptions

Every condition in the chain always runs: Once one condition succeeds, later alternatives are skipped.

Two if statements behave like if then elif: Independent if statements can both run and overwrite a result.

Indentation is cosmetic: Leading spaces define the branch body.

Every branch tested means every input correct: A missing equality case can hide a wrong comparison.

Use Section 9 for the evidence ledger. Add a boundary or missing-input case and record the expected response before checking. More successful repeats of one case do not establish wider coverage.

Match the support to the first error

What the response shows · Next teaching action

What the response shows: Missing or misread facts

Next teaching action: Read the case aloud, mark supplied versus unknown facts, and let the learner restate it.

What the response shows: Wrong procedure

Next teaching action: Return to the deciding step in the worked case. Contrast it with the proposed incorrect explanation.

What the response shows: Arithmetic or implementation error

Next teaching action: Trace intermediate values or lines; preserve the first mismatch and retry that step.

What the response shows: Correct result without a reason

Next teaching action: Ask for a trace and a changed case before marking independent understanding.

What the response shows: An unsupported wider claim

Next teaching action: Ask which supplied evidence supports the claim and which further observation would be needed.

Offer an oral explanation, drawing, enlarged visual or fewer examples when that removes a reading/writing barrier. Keep the same reasoning goal. Stretch secure learners by changing a boundary or assumption and asking them to defend the effect, not simply by assigning more of the same questions.

5. Assess and explain the answers

Guided and exit questions

The faulty < 12 version prints Long for 12, contrary to the inclusive Short rule. Repair to ≤ 12 and rerun 11 or 13 as well as 12. Exit: exact 12 is missing. -1, 2 and 20 can visit all branches even when the equality comparison is wrong.

W1 Explain the chain

Describe the purpose of if, elif and else in the worked duration sorter. Explain why print(label) is outside the indented branches.

if tests negative first; elif checks ≤ 12 only after that fails; else handles the rest. Unindented print runs after any selected branch, whose assignment gives label a value.

W2 Trace the tested path

For -1, 12 and 13, record checked conditions, skipped conditions and the final label. Run each as a fresh script after predicting.

-1: first True, second skipped, Invalid. 12: first False, second True, Short. 13: both False, else selected, Long. Retain observed results separately.

W3 Repair the overwritten result

Trace the two-independent-if example for -1. Identify which assignment overwrites the earlier label and make the smallest repair.

The first assignment sets Invalid; the second if also succeeds and changes label to Short. Replace the second if with elif. The repaired output is Invalid.

W4 Build a new sorter independently

Use an integer tiles count. Label a negative value Invalid, zero Empty, 1 through 6 Small and values above 6 Large. Write an ordered if elif else script and predict -1, 0, 1, 6 and 7. Include one print after the chain.

Use if tiles < 0, elif tiles == 0, elif tiles ≤ 6 , else, assigning the respective labels and printing after the chain. Outputs Invalid, Empty, Small, Small, Large. Zero must be handled before the ≤ 6 branch.

W5 Choose revealing regression tests

A repair changes the small-count condition from < 6 to ≤ 6 . Name the case that exposes the original error and two different kinds of earlier cases to rerun.

6 exposes the original wrong Large label. Rerun zero for Empty and a negative count for Invalid, or 7 for Large. Passing only 6 does not check earlier branches.

Independent assessment and fresh retry

W4 must assign one correct label on all five cases and explain zero before the small branch. After support, retry a shelf-count sorter with Empty at zero, Few for 1 through 4, Many above 4 and Invalid below zero. Expected outputs at -1, 0, 4, 5 are Invalid, Empty, Few, Many.

Assess independent transfer

Selected case: Predict the action for 30, then trace 29 and -1. Explain why validity is checked before the lamp decision.

```
reading = 30

if not 0 <= reading <= 100:
```

```
    action = "invalid"

elif reading < 30:

    action = "on"

else:

    action = "off"

print(action)
```

Selected case answer

30 gives off, 29 gives on, -1 gives invalid. Checking validity first prevents an invalid negative reading from being accepted as a lamp-on decision.

Dimension · Evidence required

Dimension: Explanation

Evidence required: Names the applicable idea or procedure and ties it to the supplied facts.

Dimension: Trace and result

Evidence required: Preserves the given inputs and shows the relevant intermediate steps; distinguishes a prediction from an observed execution.

Dimension: Limits

Evidence required: States the assumptions, missing evidence or conditions under which the result would change.

Record each dimension as not yet, with support, or independent. Accept a valid alternative procedure with a defensible trace. Do not penalise an honestly recorded model failure if the learner correctly explains its evidence and limits.

Feedback that the learner uses

Name the earliest unsupported step and give one action to repair it. Have the learner make that repair now and explain why. Then assess the relevant skill on a fresh, fully specified case. Confirm it was not previously practised with feedback; solve and check the new case before assigning it. A follow-up design prompt is a starting brief, not automatically an equivalent test.

6. Connect the project, support and next lesson

Add a labelled branching and boundary tests evidence sheet to Python readiness portfolio. Show how you can trace the selected branch in an if elif else chain. Use the supplied fictional case and keep its inputs, intermediate steps, calculation or prediction, and limitation. Connect this record to last week's record; a matching answer without a trace is insufficient.

Provide movable branch cards and align the four-space blocks on a ruled page. Permit an oral trace alongside the script and record help. Extension: swap the zero and ≤ 6 checks and find the smallest nonnegative counterexample.

Week 6 repeats a block with loops and records each change in state.

Retain the project ledger and assess a changed case after support. Check the relevant prerequisite before carrying this component forward.

Plan the delayed return

Suggested return points in this level: python-bridge/6, python-bridge/8, python-bridge/11. Use actual classroom dates, adjusting for holidays and gaps. One, three and six teaching weeks are scheduling choices, not a claimed optimal spacing.

At a delayed check, ask for the idea from memory and a changed application. Compare with the earlier independent response and record support used. For a new level, revisit the previous capstone before checking the new prerequisites.

Record · Teacher evidence

Record: Learner code and date

Teacher evidence: _____

Record: Concept and case used; prior exposure

Teacher evidence: _____

Record: Explanation / trace / limits

Teacher evidence: _____

Record: Support and first repair

Teacher evidence: _____

Record: Changed case and delayed outcome

Teacher evidence: _____

Record: Next teaching action

Teacher evidence: _____

Use the evidence to choose reteaching or the next step. A completed page, confidence rating or attractive project does not by itself demonstrate understanding.

Project evidence from this case

For Python readiness before the Responsible Plant Classifier, retain a trace of the values, the predicted outputs and the changed-case explanation. Use actual Python 3 results to check the prediction after reasoning first.